WOMEN'S SAFETY & SECURITY PROJECT

OUR VOICE MATTERS

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The Paradox of Fear: Women's Perceptions of Safety in Public Open Spaces and the Implications for Liveable Cities

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Cairo- Egypt

Chester- UK

"أنا نفسي أتمشى" or in English "**I aspire to walk**" the desire itself is radical in some contexts. In Egypt, **99.3% of women** have experienced **sexual harassment** in public spaces according to the UNFPA (2013).

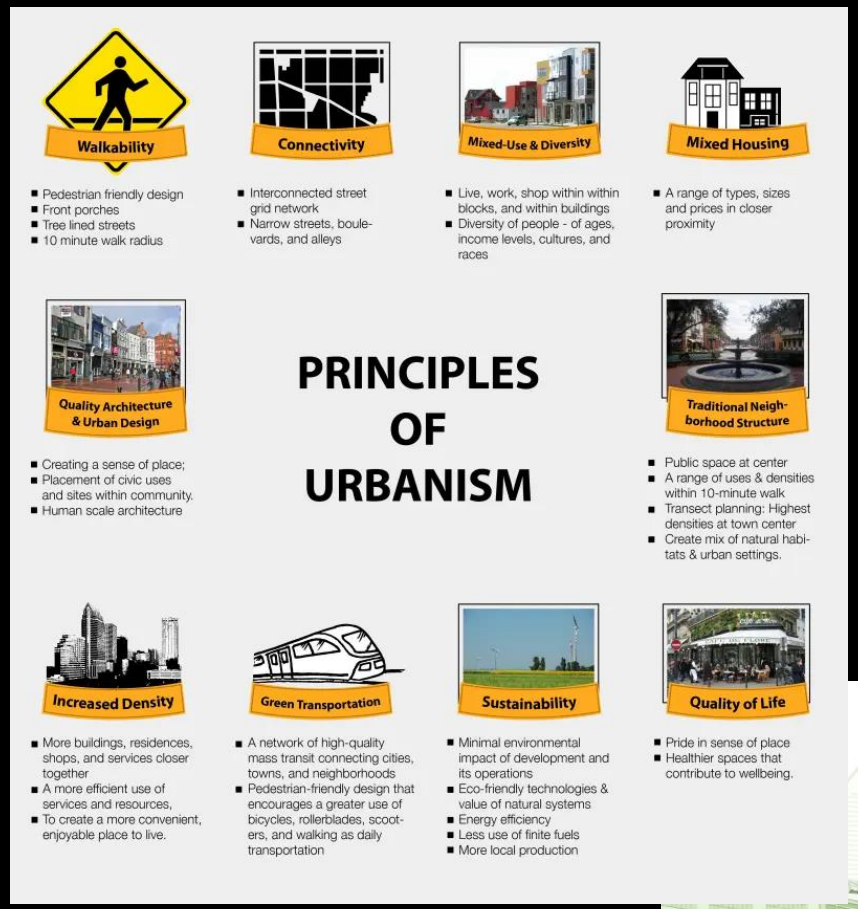
Cairo streets are patrolled **not only by traffic** but by **social surveillance and unspoken gender rules.**

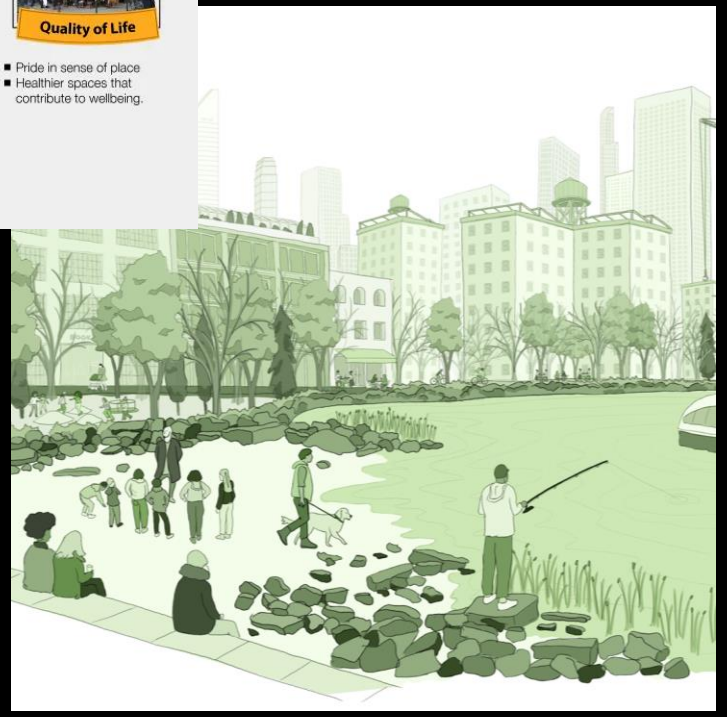
Women's safety is often approached through **control (CCTV, lighting)** but what about **emotional and spatial justice**?

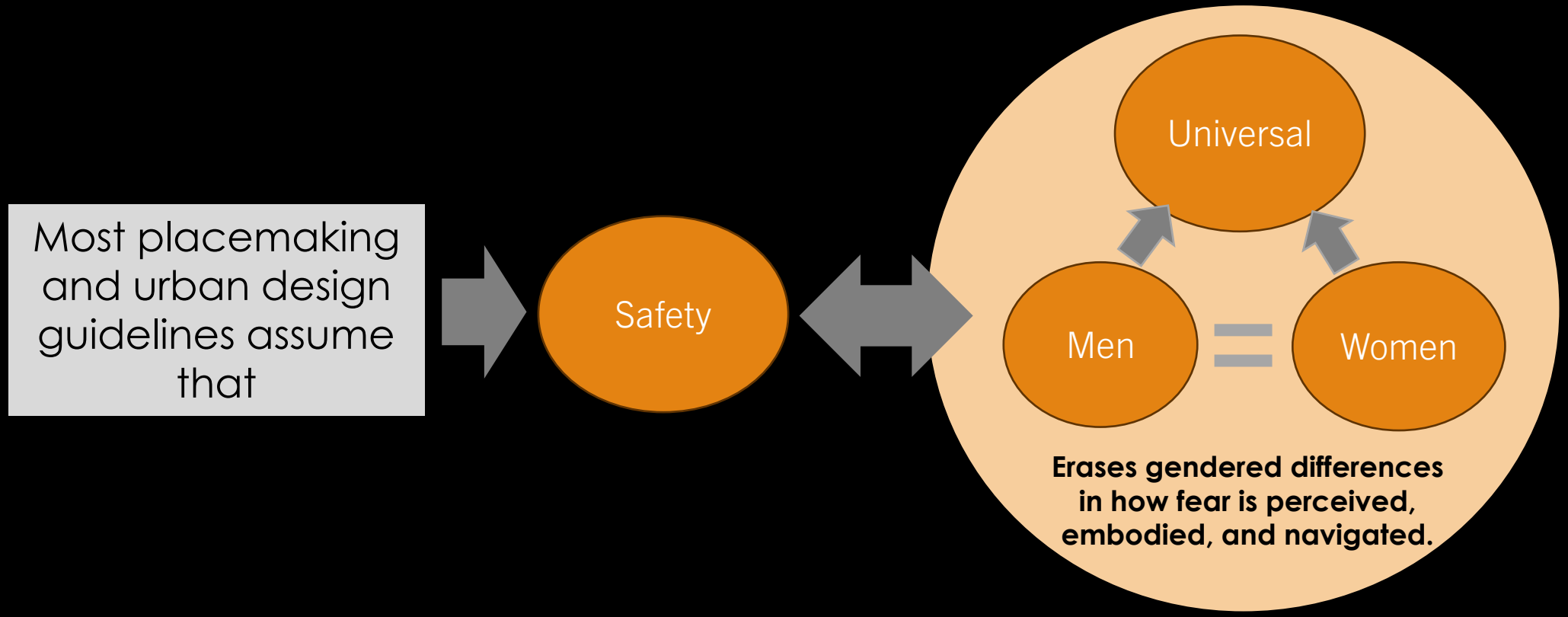
This project asks:

- **How do women experience fear in public open spaces?**
- **What shapes those perceptions infrastructure, culture, memory, surveillance?**
- **How can urban planning respond not only to danger, but to discomfort?**

Cities are often measured **by how green or walkable they are** but not by **how comfortable or safe women feel walking in them.**







What produces women's fear in public spaces and how can we plan differently? This is both a theoretical and a political question.

As Senetra and colleagues (2024) showed, "***gendered safety is not just about crime prevention it's about emotional, cultural, and symbolic dimensions that are deeply embodied.***"

Who speaks?
Who listens?

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Feminist urban theorists have long challenged the idea **that cities are neutral**.

Sandercock (1992) argued that **traditional planning** is shaped by **hierarchical dualities**

Theory	⟷	**Practice**
Knowledge	⟷	**Experience**
Private	⟷	**Public**

*"The planning and design of cities is **male dominated**. So, as a result, there is **significant bias** over who **gets consideration** when building the public space."* Dr Pablo Navarrete-Hernandez

PARADOX OF WOMEN'S FEAR

Women who were **less likely than men** to experience **violence in public** and **much more likely** to experience it in **the home**, consistently reported **fear of men in public**.

Feminist perspective **takes power dynamics** into account, **woman's experience** of the threat of **sexual violence** creates the paradox and explains **difference between women's and men's experiences of fear** (Valentine, 1990; Pain, 1991; Madge, 1997; Koskela, 1999; Özascilar, 2013; Kern, 2020)

As Carolyn Whitzman (1996) articulates, **the nature of fear of crime between women and men is different**. "The crime **women** most **fear is rape**. The crime that **men** most **fear is robbery**. Robbery is a **bad thing** to have happen to you. **Rape is worse**."

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CURRENT TRENDS

95% Of **500 participant** in Delhi stated that they usually **carry with them an object for self-protection**, also how they **change their clothes** or the **times they go out or not** to avoid feeling **uncomfortable** while being **out of their homes** (Jagori, 2006).

55% A study has shown that 55% of women in the **European Union** have experienced a form of **sexual harassment** since **the age of 15** (European Parliament, 2018).

71% In the UK, **71% of women** experienced **sexual harassment in public areas** (UN-Women, 2021).

18% Of women always or often feel **unsafe** when **exercising in an outdoor public space**

84% of women have experienced **sexual harassment** in **Leeds' city centre**, which is **higher than the national** statistics (Women-Friendly-Leeds, 2021).

Why Leeds? Why This Case?

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- Leeds is the **3rd largest UK city**, population ~**812,000** (ONS, 2023)
- 19% ethnic minorities (Census 2021); increasing urban diversity
- Over £**100 million** invested in **public green space and city centre regeneration** (Leeds Inclusive Growth Strategy 2020–25)
- **41% of women** reported feeling **unsafe walking alone after dark in parks** (Leeds Safer Spaces, 2022)
- Women in **East Leeds 3×** more likely to report **fear in public space vs. those in Headingley** (LCC 2022)
- Fear linked to visibility, class, and race especially in transit zones.

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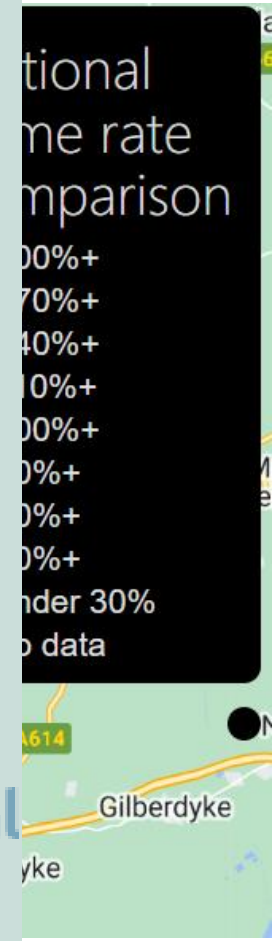
Most crim mmitted in the city. V



Methodology

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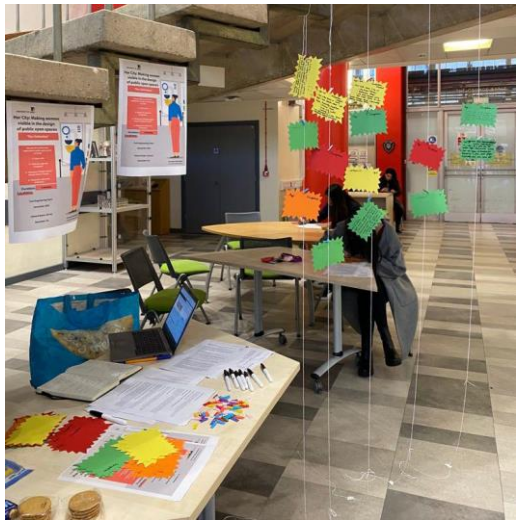
Participatory and **visual research practices** allowed to centre **women's voices, feelings, and spatial knowledge** and to move beyond just **'asking questions'** toward '**co-producing meaning**'.

- **23 semi-structured interviews** with women aged 19–65 from diverse racial, ethnic, and religious backgrounds.
- **3 focus groups** using visual elicitation including sketch maps, route tracing, and discussion of photos from participants' daily lives.
- **The Clothesline Method** enabled women to anonymously share fears and ideas by pinning notes to a public line. It revealed common concerns like **harassment, poor lighting, and distrust in authorities offering a powerful, low-barrier way to surface lived experiences**



Leeds Designing Discomfort

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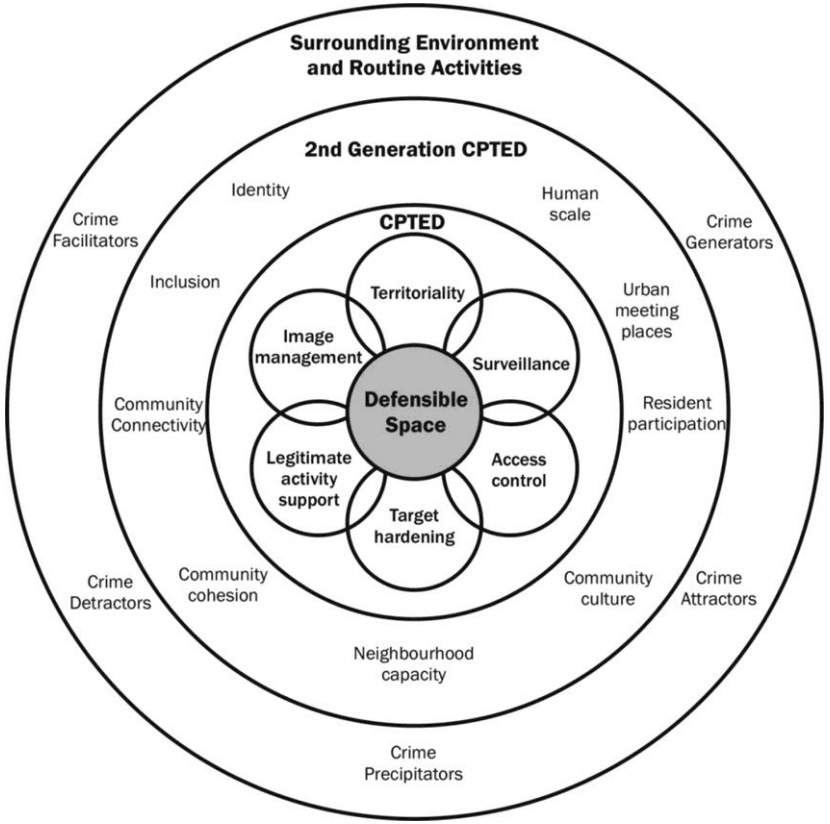
- Traditional urban design prioritises visibility and control over comfort and care
- CPTED focuses **on lighting, fencing, CCTV not on emotional safety**
- Women often feel "**visible but not protected** "***The cameras see me but they're not for me.***" Interviewee, Leeds 2024



Women's Strategies of Navigation

CHART 4: WHICH, IF ANY, OF THE FOLLOWING HAVE YOU EVER PERSONALLY EXPERIENCED?

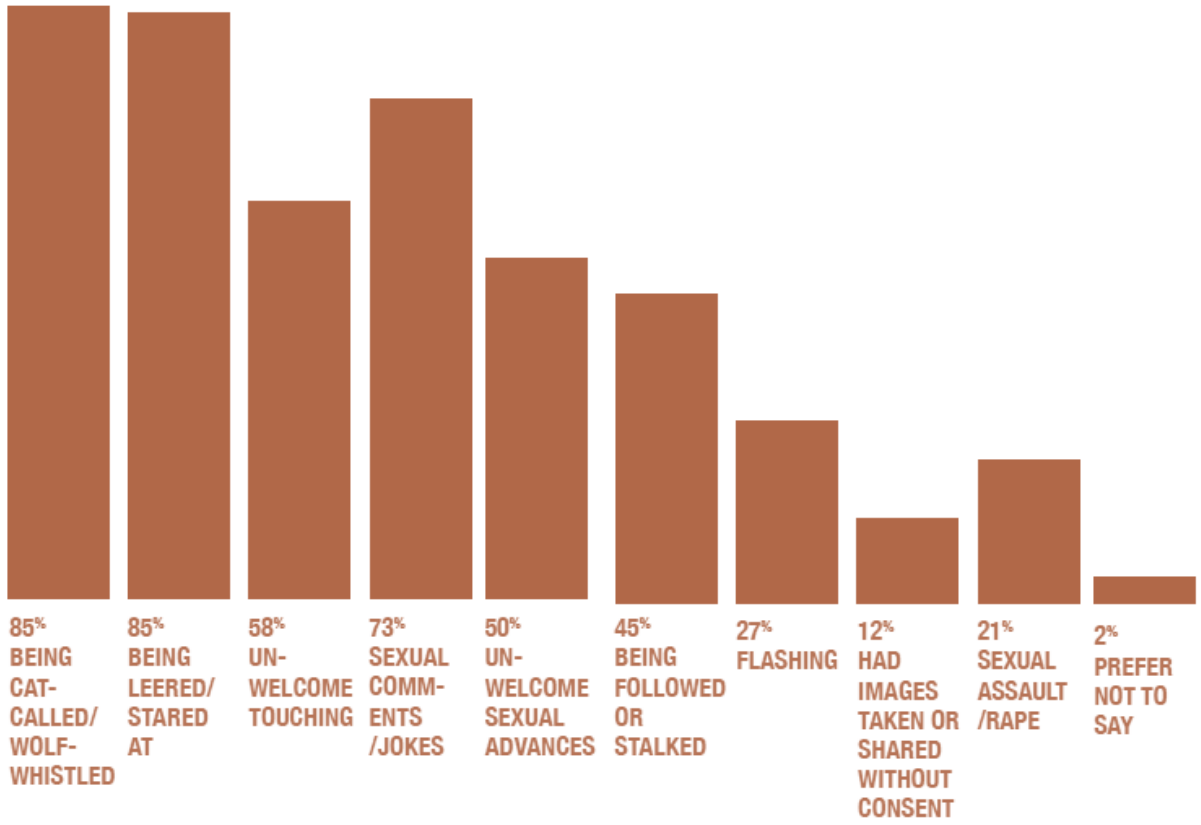


CHART 2: OVERALL, HOW SAFE YOU FEEL WHEN OUT AND ABOUT IN LEEDS DURING THE DAY?

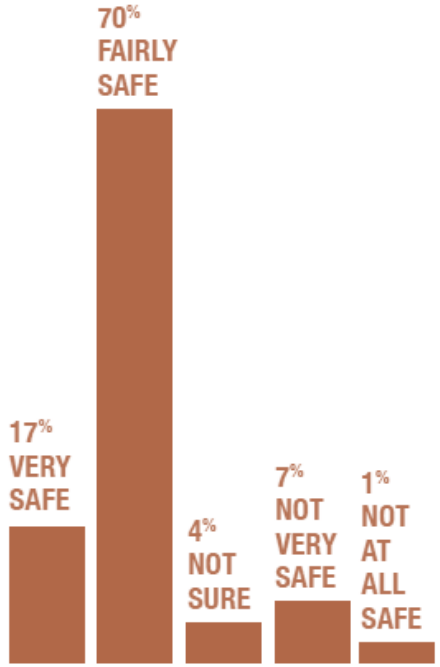
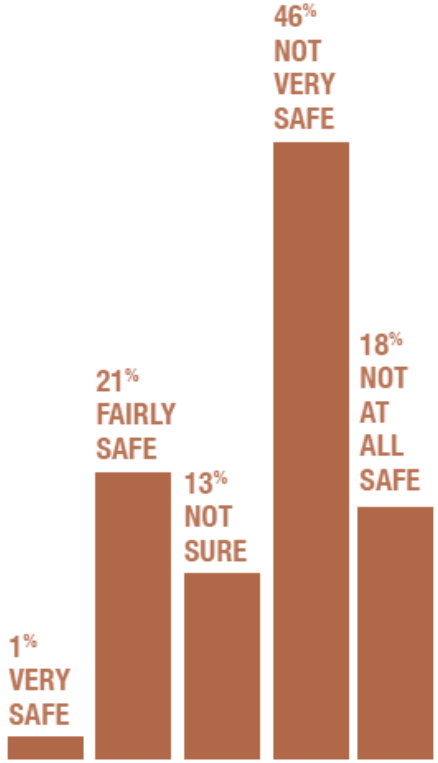


CHART 3: OVERALL, HOW SAFE DO YOU FEEL BEING OUT AND ABOUT IN LEEDS AFTER DARK?

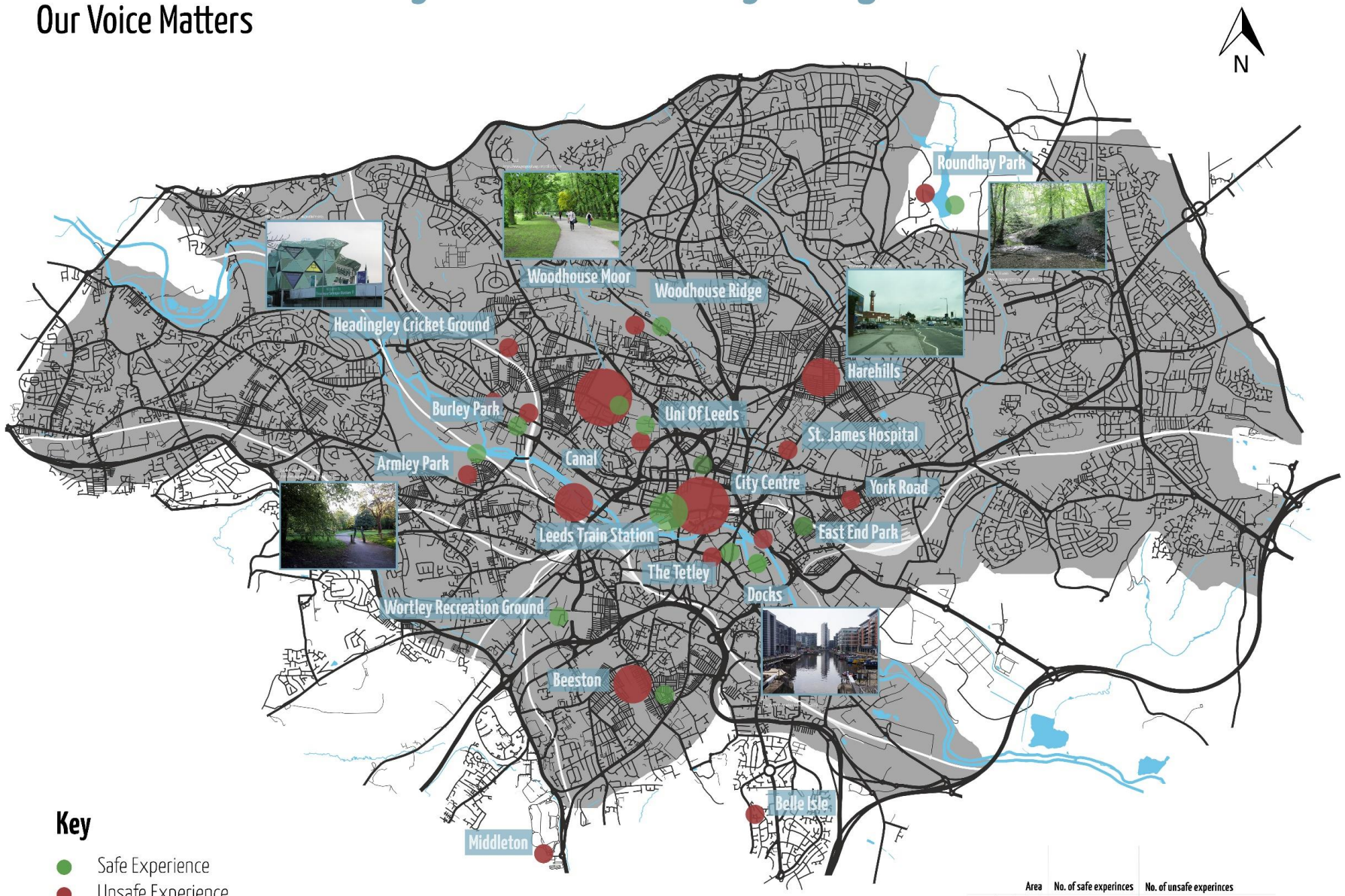


"Taking **longer routes** home which **feel safer**". Interviewee, 2024

"Feeling **less safe** walking the **canal at certain** times of the day. **Very vulnerable**, no traffic or people around to help if **someone attacked**" Interviewee, 2024

Women's Safety And Security Project

Our Voice Matters



Key

- Safe Experience
- Unsafe Experience
- Roads
- Blue Infrastructure

Incident Numbers

Area	No. of safe experinces	No. of unsafe experinces
Armley Park	0	5
Beeston	5	40
Belle Isle	0	5
Burley Park	5	5
Canal	0	30

Taking longer routes home which feel safer.

Woodhouse Moor, unsafe at nightime, stories of assault.

Never feeling relaxed when walking by myself in the dark.

Roundhay Park. No lighting in park at all. Multiple flashers at the moment.

Picking walking routes where visibility is better: less walls, alleways, buildings.

Trinity feels safe, lots of lighting.

Feel safer when women are around, protection.

The docks, walking down the canals at night. No escape route if you get in trouble.

Diverse (giving the feeling of belonging).

Lots of lighting.

Having to call people on the phone to feel safer.

Feeling less safe walking the canal at certain times of the day. Very vulnerable, no traffic or people around to help if someone attacked.

Often feel safe in centre because lots of people around who could help me.

I don't feel safe in Hyde Park or Woodhouse Moor because of the lack of lighting.

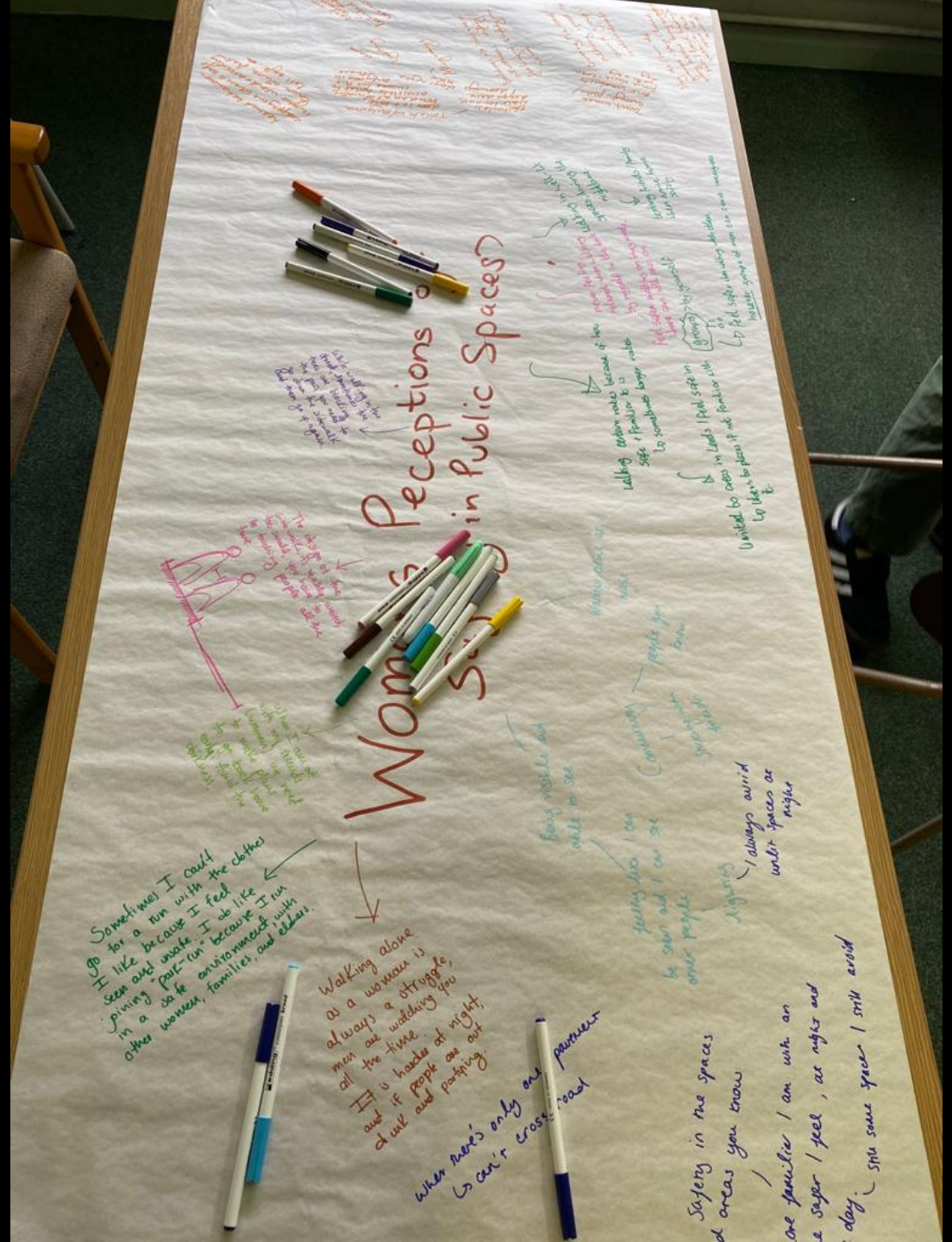
External Factors: Spatial configuration and socio-cultural construct

Street network configurations that induce desolated streets can create unconducive environment for women. For instance, the belief within certain cultures that women are more bounded to the domestic realm has curbed women's mobility beyond the home.

Perceptions of safety is highly individualised and subject to personal risk acceptability thresholds in relation to age, physical ability and socio-cultural background.

Internal factors: Individual characteristics and place

Individual characteristics and socio-cultural factors influence how people perceive and attach meaning to places. Positive associations foster place attachment, potentially reducing street crimes and improving safety perceptions.



Engaging **with rights and gender urban planning** requires a **nuanced approach avoiding rigid directives** that may **disconnect** from **underlying political issues**

A gendered perspective on rights underscores the need for caution regarding the transformative potential of current conceptualisations of the right to the city.

Urban experiences can **empower or marginalise**, emphasising the **political dimensions of everyday life.** Can **dynamic representations of urban space** foster inclusive environments and advance claims

THANK YOU

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